

Research Note: Trade Unions, Conflict, and the Nature of Work in Residential Service Organizations¹

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Abstract

Conflicts involving trade unions in fourteen small residential service organizations (RSOs)—children's homes, old peoples' homes, and probation hostels—in a western county in England over a 20-month period are studied via a grounded theory methodology. Results indicate that (1) multiple and competing unions stimulate intraworker conflict and complicate labour-management relations; (2) unions representing RSO workers are pragmatic and work-conditions oriented in their collective bargaining activities; and (3) unions' efforts to negotiate the 'nature of work' for their members are based on the 'ideology of service' which pervades British society and views persons dependent on the state for 'basic human needs' as 'deserving' to have those needs met. This 'service ideology' is both exploited by the unions to define workers' jobs and used by management and society to prevent organized RSO workers from employing the 'strike' as a collective bargaining option. Union efforts to negotiate work in RSOs are viewed as dialogues regarding not only workers' rights but the *nature and rights of the residents themselves*. Additional research is called for on the role of trade unions in organizations in which the 'object' of work consists of fellow human beings.

Introduction

As noted by Martin and Kassalow (1980: viii), '... much of the industrial relations landscape of Europe, Japan, and the United States remains unexplored'. This is especially true of labour-management relations in the personal social services. The continuing expansion of the so-called tertiary—or service—sector of developed economies (Schmidman 1979) and of social services of both a residential and nonresidential nature underscores the importance of greater understanding of the role of trade unions in service organizations (Hasenfeld 1983).

Debate over the consequences of union expansion in the service sector of developed nations ranges from Schmidman's (1979) championing of workplace unions as the greatest democratizing force in postindustrial society to Lieberman's (1980) damning of unions as 'polluting the political process' and lowering worker productivity. The present analysis is unable to resolve this question but can enhance understanding of the development of trade unions in

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the personal social service sector of one developed nation. This research note describes and analyses labour-management relations in small, residential service organizations in Great Britain with a focus on the conditions and nature of conflicts between lower-level workers and upper-level management. A number of issues are addressed, including: (1) the effects of multiple unions as well as union and nonunion workers in one work setting (cf. Leminsky 1980); (2) whether unions in a recently unionized sector of the economy are ideological/social change oriented or pragmatic/work-conditions oriented (Schmidman 1979); and (3) the nature of union dynamics in work contexts where the *raw material*, or the object of work, consists of human beings rather than inanimate materials or objects (Johnston 1978; Lipsky 1980).

Related to the latter point, attention is given to the nature of work performed in the personal social services (see Lipsky 1980). It can be argued that work in this service sector differs qualitatively from that in the primary (agricultural), secondary (manufacturing), and other types of tertiary (service) sectors (e.g. banking, transportation) of developed economies. The *object* of work in residential service organizations consists of cognizant, active human beings—e.g. old people, children, probationers—who are fundamentally dependent on the workers for the 'necessities of life' (food, shelter, etc.). Through their efforts to influence the 'definition of work' in residential service organizations, trade unions enter into a 'moral' (Levy 1982) dialogue with management (and, ultimately, the state) regarding the rights not only of their members but of the residents themselves. Better understanding of this complex and contradictory process can provide insights regarding the potential shape of future industrial relations in postindustrial society.

The paper is organized as follows. A definition of residential service organizations (RSOs) is presented including consideration of the problematic nature of the concept of 'service'. The theoretical perspective guiding the analysis is acknowledged as radical Weberian (see Burrell and Morgan 1979), which assumes conflicts of material interest to characterize all authority relations. The sample and methodology are described, followed by analysis of conflicts involving trade unions in residential service organizations. The concluding discussion focuses on the 'ideology of service' relative to the nature of work and the role of unions in RSOs.

Residential Service Organizations: A Definition

Residential service organizations (RSOs) are formal organizations which provide personal social services—primarily food, shelter, and companionship—to live-in 'clients' (here called residents) on a 24-hour/day, year-round basis. Following Hasenfeld (1983:6), RSOs are viewed as people-sustaining rather than people-processing (e.g. juvenile courts, credit rating offices) or people-changing human service organizations (e.g. schools, hospitals). Small residential establishments such as those under study are typically located in

residential neighbourhoods and integrated into the routines of community life (e.g. children attend local schools; probationers hold jobs). Such organizations appeared with urbanization and industrialization for a number of reasons, including the increased longevity of the citizenry and a reaction against the warehousing effects of large 'institutions' (Wolins and Wozner 1982). Small RSOs constitute a societal response of developed nations to people without shelter, resources, or the ability to care for themselves (e.g. the young, the elderly) or who 'require' official supervision or surveillance (e.g., probationers) as determined by the state.

Although the primary work of RSO employees is often described as 'serving the residential clients' (Morris 1976), two conceptual problems beset this description. First, the term 'service' may fail to accurately represent activities performed against the wishes of the immediate 'recipient' and at the direction of the state (see Lipsky 1980; Mayhew 1981; Martin et al. 1983). Is an old person forced by social workers and the courts to leave home and enter an old peoples' home being 'served'? What about children removed from their families and placed in assessment centres? Second, the answer to such questions revolves around identification of the 'client'—the person or entity for whom the 'service' is ultimately performed. Is the child-in-care (or old person) the service recipient or his parents (or children) who did not want him at home? Is the hostel probationer the recipient of service or the society (state) who prefers 'deviants' removed from its midst? Martin et al. (1983) emphasize the unacceptability of a concept of service defined as whatever 'official service providers' do 'in the name of service'. An ideological conception of service (Goldner 1982) as described and buttressed by organizations acting on behalf of the state has, to date, been accepted in the human service literature rather than subjected to critical analysis (Austin 1978). As suggested by Goldner (1982), terms other than 'service' and 'client' must be found to accurately reflect the complexities of worker/object relations (since the *object* of work in this case *is a subject*) in the growing personal social service sector of welfare state societies (Schmidman 1979).

Both workers and residents of RSOs daily confront contradictions between claims associated with the 'ideology of service' and the realities of power and material conflicts of interest inherent in a hierarchical bureaucracy where workers are subject to the authority of management (and the state) and residents, to the authority of both workers and management (and the state). As subsequent analysis indicates, trade unions exploit this contradiction and use the rhetoric of the service ideology to recruit new members and negotiate a division of labour beneficial to their membership.

Theoretical Perspective

In line with a radical Weberian theory of organizations (Burrell and Morgan 1979), three assumptions guide the analysis. First, it is assumed that residential

service organizations cannot be understood in isolation from the 'wider social framework' within which they are located (Miliband 1973). They are viewed as reflections of class and gender relations in British society and as objects of ideological manipulation by ruling interest groups on the outside (primarily controllers of the state). Second, it is assumed that inequalities and contradictions inherent in hierarchical bureaucracy and in the 'ideology of service' (Lipsky 1980; Goldner 1982) will surface in the form of power relations between management and labour and that these will lead to conflict. Third, conflict is viewed as a usual and to-be-expected aspect of organizational reality. In all work contexts characterized by authority relations, chronic conflicts abound between those who enjoy the benefits of the hierarchical structure and those who are the 'object' of it (de Kervasdoué and Kimberly 1979; Schmidman 1979). Chronic conflicts of collective material interest are the type to which trade union attention is frequently directed and, as subsequent evidence demonstrates, the primary grounds for management-worker disputes in the present case.

Methodology

Data were collected over a 20-month period (in 1979 and 1980) from 14 residential organizations in a western county in England; included were five children's homes, seven old peoples' homes, and two probation hostels. All but three RSOs were under the auspices of the Social Services Department of the local county. The three voluntary facilities included a children's home supported by a religious order and two probation hostels, one for adult males and one for adolescents of both sexes, funded, respectively, by private, local funds and a national foundation. Data sources consisted of the following: unstructured interviews with 45 RSO managers and workers and 15 staff in the Social Service Department office of the county (for a total of over 100 hours); over 200 hours of unstructured, participant observation in the RSOs including meal times, bed times, and all hours of the day and night; observation of meetings of area management team staff, heads of homes, union locals, social services policy council, and special project and working party groups; participation in employment interviews and in staff training sessions; and examination and analysis of the following archival materials: reports on manpower, services to the elderly, investigations of irregularities, and staff training; union recruitment materials; management memoranda (both confidential and public) regarding problems and issues in the RSOs; house rules and other written materials present in the RSOs; and newspaper articles about the RSOs. Data collected from interviews and observations were written in the form of detailed notes with particular attention to the major themes of the overall project (leadership succession, deliberate change efforts, and trade unions in relation to organizational conflict). Persons interviewed and observed were informed only of my general interest in learning about small, residential service organizations.

Data were collected and analysed in accord with guidelines of Glaser and Strauss (1967), Glaser (1978), and Turner (1981) for the generation of grounded, substantive theory. The primary goal was to inductively generate concepts useful for analytically describing structurally based conflict in the organizations under study. Since union issues were observed to vary more with organizational size than organizational type, the analysis proceeds on the assumption that conflict relative to unions is similar for different RSO types. Very small RSOs tended, that is, to have few union members regardless of type (children, old people, or probation) and larger ones had many union members regardless of type.

Unions and Conflict

Conflict in the form of overt verbal hostilities was fairly rare in the RSOs under study; even rarer was conflict of a physical nature. Conflicts reflecting a divergence of interests—both material and otherwise—were, however, pervasive. The topic of unions and conflict is discussed under four headings: description of the situation; issues for routine bargaining; management's view of workers' unions; and issues prompting labour-management conflict.

Description of the Situation

(1) Multiple and competing unions. Because British unions are organized occupationally or industrially rather than by 'company' or worksite (Korpi 1980) it is difficult for workers in a single organization to speak with one voice (Leminsky 1980:159). Residential service workers are no exception. Although British social service workers only gained the right to 'organize' as recently as 1975 (with passage of the Industrial Relations Act of 1975), a sizeable proportion of RSO employees belonged to unions by 1980 (Davis 1981). Though empirically rare, staff in a single RSO can potentially belong to five different unions as well as to no union at all. Some unions compete for the same workers whereas others separate along occupation and authority lines, making 'task' and rank demarcations more distinct than might otherwise be true.

The five unions are as follows. The National Association of Local Government Officers (NALGO) is the fourth largest union in England and the one to which RSO management staff typically belong (as do senior social service personnel in county government). The Confederation of Health Service Employees (COHSE) is England's 12th largest union. Staff with health qualifications belong as do RSO 'caring staff', such as house parents in children's homes and those who assist the elderly in bathing, dressing, toileting, etc. in old peoples' homes. An RSO director who is also a state registered nurse may belong to both NALGO and COHSE. The Transport and General Workers Union (the largest national union in England), the National Union of Public Employees (fifth largest), and the General and Municipal Workers Union (third largest)

recruit primarily unskilled workers such as domestics (those who clean), cooks, ambulance drivers, seamstresses, and so forth. These unions compete for members and, although an interunion agreement (the Bidlington Agreement) forbids it, one occasionally 'poaches' from the others.

Although all five are national unions, bargaining (and agreements) and grievances are handled at the local (county) level. From the RSOs under county social services, county administrators rather than individual RSO managers bargain with union representatives. The presence of multiple unions and nonunionized staff stimulates considerable dissent. Unionized staff are suspicious of competing union members and resentful that nonunion staff benefit from bargaining and contractual agreements without contributing to the union or 'taking the risks' they perceive themselves as taking. Nonunion staff are afraid to go to work when a strike or other form of industrial action is taken. RSO managers fear internal conflicts among staff when industrial action of one union is resented or objected to by staff in other unions (and by the residents).

Workers in some RSOs emphasize the separation of tasks along job description and status lines, a situation exacerbated by differing union memberships. 'Caring' staff, who belong primarily to COHSE, and 'domestic' staff, who belong to the general workers' unions, wear different coloured clothing (jumpers over street clothes) in some RSOs and share normative proscriptions regarding performance of duties associated with the other 'job'. Domestic staff resent their own members 'chatting with residents' which, in official job descriptions, is a 'caring staff duty' and which, when done by a domestic, is viewed as 'loafing on the job'. The irony of such concerns is underscored by an advantage in pay by caring staff over domestic staff of only £1.00 per week. Multiple unions in this case rigidify worker divisions and prevent solidarity and presentation of a united front to either management or the larger social context.

In contrast to production organizations, where management is associated with owners or capital, management staff in RSOs are themselves, typically, union members. Though some managers view NALGO as 'more a professional association than a union', NALGO is indeed a trade union and has been responsible for strike action by social workers in numerous English counties. (See Thornton 1982 for a discussion of similar issues among English school teachers.) Management personnel view their NALGO membership as a 'defensive' (cf. Schmidman 1979) measure in the event of legal disputes and redundancies (layoffs). Ironically, NALGO is unable to help if the subordinate (or superior) in legal disputes is also a NALGO member. As might be expected, management staff expressed little ideological commitment to the usual goals of collective organizing and bargaining (Johnston 1978) and, indeed, were ambivalent about the involvement of RSO workers in union activities.

(2) Wages. Wages and salaries are low for all social service workers in England and particularly low for RSO personnel. The average annual wage in 1979 for

lower level workers was less than £2,000. Management salaries were 1½ to three or more times higher (depending primarily on the number of residents in the facility). Union dues also were low ranging from £1.00 to £1.50 monthly (with dues paid weekly, such as 25p/week). Unions are unsuccessful in securing higher wages for RSO workers (due in part to their being unskilled and female; see *Social Work Today* 1979), thus bargaining tends to concentrate on working conditions and other material benefits.

(3) Revenues. Revenues for personal social services, including RSOs, come primarily from local rates (property taxes), in competition with transportation and education. Education is the first priority of local and county governments (Lawrence 1980:53–57) and social service funding is generally last. Within the social services, furthermore, funding for residential care is a low priority (*Social Work Today* 1979).

(4) Operations. Residential service organizations are in continuous operation 24 hours/day, 365 days/year. Staffing is usually minimal (due to low revenues), thus staff absences resulting from holidays, leave, and illness added to those due to emergencies (winter storms), 'sick outs' (Levine and Taira 1980), and other absenteeism often lead to staff shortages. Work demands in such settings are, as a consequence, viewed by staff as excessive at times and intense and demanding generally.

(5) Staff. In regards to authority, RSO staff fall into two categories: management and workers. Management typically entails three positions: an officer-in-charge (or director), a deputy director, and a third-in-charge. Larger establishments and establishments with more problematic residents (such as severely disturbed children) may also have a fourth-in-charge. Officers-in-charge typically have apartments in the facility and many (about 60%) use it as their primary domicile. Other management staff seldom 'live-in', although they regularly have to 'sleep over' (at no extra pay) since at least one management person must be in the facility at all times. Workers' primary occupational roles are of three types: (1) caring, or the direct supervision and oversight of residents; (2) domestic, primarily cleaning (floors, toilets, changing of beds); and (3) kitchen work, including cooking, serving meals, and washing up. Larger (or more complex) facilities often have seamstresses, laundresses, maintenance personnel, and drivers. Employees tend to be hired either as management or as workers and to remain in these categories. There is little internal promotion which allows workers to advance into management.

In the present sample, 85 per cent of RSO workers are female as are 60 per cent of the management staff. The historical predominance of females in RSOs is reflected in the generic use of the term 'matron' to refer to RSO directors, particularly in old peoples' homes. The primary tasks in RSOs are, in many respects, extensions of the normative housewife's roles of nurturing, cleaning, and cooking (Davies 1979). Previous research has shown that women workers are disadvantaged in developed nations by a segmented labour market (Barron and Norris 1976; Bibb and Form 1977) which channels them into low status,

low paying jobs and into labour intensive, unskilled market sectors where unionization brings few benefits in regards to either wages or job security. This should be kept in mind as the analysis proceeds.

Issues for Routine Bargaining

Consistent with Schmidman's (1979) predictions for service sector unions in postindustrial society, the orientation of union leaders and members in RSOs is pragmatic rather than highly ideological or macro, social change oriented. The issues over which routine bargaining occur are: wages; working conditions (job descriptions; issues related to time: days of the week/week-end assignments, hours of work such as scheduling and the total required, break and leave times, opportunities for overtime; and privileges such as use of a commons room); benefits (e.g. sick leave, disability, overtime pay); and job security (e.g. termination criteria). For numerous reasons, unions have been unsuccessful in improving members' wages, thus have concentrated on other goals with considerable success. With RSO continuous, year-round operation, the days and hours of work (as well as the total hours/week) are a perennial source of labour-management conflict. Workers prefer weekdays to weekends, day work to night duty, and leave time on holidays and special occasions. Union negotiations have successfully reduced the workers' total hours/week to 37.5, a considerably lower number than management's weekly average (45 hours if sleep-over time is not counted; 65 to 70, if it is). Workers earn overtime pay for hours above 37.5 (whereas salaried management staff do not), which sometimes leads to a larger pay at week's end than management's, an event occasioning resentment on the latter's part.

One aspect of work over which unions bargained in 1979 concerned the authority of management to assign workers to duties not specified in their job descriptions. Due to limited staff and the rigours of continuous operation, management believe they must have authority to require workers to perform work outside their job descriptions—e.g. assign a caring worker to assist in the kitchen or a domestic to help dress residents. One union used this issue in its printed literature as a recruitment theme. A flier addressed to 'All Care Assistants' (i.e., caring staff) read:

'Is there the correct balance between care assistant hours and domestic hours? If you are washing up, preparing meals, etc., there is something wrong. If domestics have to help with your duties, e.g. bathing, toileting, etc., then there is something wrong. We can help if you want us to.'

Management do whatever they can, discreetly, to discourage union efforts of this type. Management's resistance to enforcement of strict job descriptions as a part of union bargaining agreements is illustrated in the following comment.

'It would be disastrous for us if [Union X] were to go through with this thing [i.e. insist a person with a given job title do only what is in his/her job description]. In a way, we

agree with their goals . . . if we had enough staff, then we could stick with strict job descriptions. We want more staff, so the work will be less on any given person, just like *they* do. But if they carry through on this, they'll close us down. We want more staff as bad as they do but this just isn't the way to get it.' (Male, mid-forties, middle-manager in county social services)

In hiring interviews, prospective employees are routinely asked about their willingness to 'pitch in' and do other 'jobs' as needed and are clearly expected by the interview panel to answer affirmatively. Workers perceived as 'flexible' on this issue are hired over those thought to be otherwise.

Management's Views of Unions

As suggested by the foregoing, RSO management are ambivalent towards unions and the rights of workers to organize and bargain. On the positive side, management support in principle the right of workers to unionize and bargain. As noted earlier, most of them are union members too. They believe workers are grossly underpaid and acknowledge that their jobs are in many respects uninteresting, dull, routine, physically demanding (e.g. in lifting the elderly or dealing with rowdy children) and, at times, unpleasant, stressful, and 'dirty'. At the same time, workers' efforts to gain greater control over the workplace are generally viewed by management as undesirable.

Areas in which management resist and resent workers' union efforts include the following. Union grievance and due-process rules are believed to unduly limit the authority to discipline or fire workers whose performance is viewed as incompetent, unreliable, or disruptive. Management perceive the 'industrial action tribunals' (the Subcommittee of the County Social Services Committee who hear grievances not resolved at lower levels) as inappropriately failing to support their decisions, which then undermines their morale and fundamental ability to lead and govern. Management deplore the loss of 'effort' on the part of shop stewards who are allowed to conduct all necessary union business (including attending meetings away from the RSO) during paid, work time, thereby depriving the already short-staffed RSO of their labour. They resent the workers' unions' success in gaining 'overtime' pay for their members while their own union is unsuccessful at this even though they often sleep over at the RSO (and are sometimes awake much of the night due to emergencies) and work extra hours (e.g. if one of the management staff is ill) with no additional compensation. Finally, they view workers' unions as stimulating dissent among the workers themselves and as complicating worker-management relationships unnecessarily.

Conflict Issues

During the 20 months of the study period, three unusual and four routine events were observed to stimulate labour-management conflict. In the first category were the following: (1) a national strike by British dustmen (garbage

collectors) and a call by their union for other union members, some of whom were RSO employees, to support the dustmen by striking themselves; (2) the attempt by one union to actively recruit workers in old peoples' homes throughout the county, including *perceived* attempts to steal members from other unions; and (3) threats by the Thatcher government to reduce social service funding which were assumed to result (and did) in redundancies. The first issue occasioned concern, particularly among management, over the likelihood and consequences of a strike by RSO workers; the second, irritation by management with the recruitment effort generally and by workers with apparent attempts to 'poach'; and the third, fear by the workers over the possible loss of jobs. Routine issues which led to threats to 'call in the union' or explicit confrontation between management and workers were as follows: changes by management of such things as staff duties, hours of work (e.g. serving the evening meal later than previously), and privileges (use of 'commons' room), etc.; workers' claims of a job-related injury (and accompanying requests for sick leave or disability benefits) contested by management as occurring elsewhere or prior to employment in the RSO; employee resistance to management efforts to terminate a worker's employment; and workers' perceptions of management's failure to follow proper procedures, act 'fairly', or respect the bargaining agreement in some action taken.

Unions and the 'Ideology of Service' in RSOs

There are multiple aspects to the 'ideology of service' discussed by Lipsky (1980), Mayhew (1981), Goldner (1982) and Martin et al. (1983). Among them are claims that (1) state actions in the name of 'service' towards its official 'clients' are in fact *beneficial* (helpful, humane, positive) to the clients; (2) services provided are *needed* by the recipient; and (3) people dependent on the state have *an unquestioned right* to receive 'services' which meet their needs. Such claims are promoted by, among others, 'official service providers' to rationalize expansion of the personal social service sector of the welfare state (Mayhew 1981). As noted earlier, whether what is actually received by those dependent on the state is 'service' or surveillance or repression is a matter of perspective and debate among critical social theorists and those aligned with 'professional' social service providers (Lipsky 1980; Goldner 1982). For present purposes, it is enough that ideological claims such as these are believed, and broadly endorsed, by the British public (Adam 1979a, 1979b, and 1979c). Social service workers are viewed by the public as lacking a legitimate right to pursue their own material interests at the expense of people who are 'dependent' on them for basic needs. This view is shared by RSO residents and their families and, based on present research, by most RSO workers and management as well.

An important consequence of such beliefs is the limitation they place on the

ability of organized labour in RSOs to use the ultimate weapon, i.e. work stoppages, particularly strikes, as a bargaining tool in the collective bargaining process. Public opinion against 'abandoning' people in residential care is strong and when national unions call their members out on strike, RSO workers are typically exempted (Wilton 1979). When the raw material of the organization consists of human beings, and, as in the case of RSOs, people who are 'dependent' on staff for food, baths, dressing, toileting, etc., the threat of strike action suggests a blatant disregard for basic human rights. Residents worry about who will prepare meals, change beds, wash clothing, give baths, and so forth and are resentful that staff would even consider striking and leaving them unattended. The elderly, particularly, hold this opinion and are supported in it by the public (Adam 1979a, 1979b, 1979c). Staff themselves are dubious about or explicitly opposed to the strike option. One union shop steward and an ambulance driver for an old people's home said he would never go on strike even if his union 'called him out' and vowed to continue to drive the elderly 'in his care' wherever they 'needed to go'.

Given the pervasiveness and force of this ideology and the indeterminacy of the fundamental 'nature of work' in human service organizations (Lipsky 1980), it is not surprising that RSO workers' unions exploit questions surrounding the nature of work in their recruitment and collective bargaining activities. They do this, furthermore, in the name of championing the rights of the residents to better 'service'. A recruitment flier of one union, addressed to unskilled workers in old peoples' homes in the county under study read as follows:

'There used to be 10% "chat time" included in the staffing levels; now with the average age at 83, there's no such thing. [Union Y] is pressing for an increase in staff to enable us to look after our elderly better . . . Defending the care of the elderly will be the task of the Trade Unions. [Union Y] will play its part with your support.'

Couched explicitly in the 'service ideology' rhetoric, such statements form a rationale for RSO workers to affiliate with a trade union. They are intended to reassure workers who, as members of society, believe that residents deserve proper 'service' and are concerned with the ethical implications of placing their 'own material interests' ahead of those of the residents. The unions' primary commitment to their members' interests, rather than to the residents', was revealed, however, as threatened reductions in social welfare funding by the Thatcher government became imminent. In a meeting of one union local, a question from a member to the leadership about concern for the 'kinds of services being provided' (i.e., if cutbacks occurred) was met with, 'Our sole concern is with jobs of our members'.

Some aspects of the ideology of service are therefore used by unions to recruit members whereas other aspects of this same ideology are used by management and society to limit the unions' options in the bargaining process, primarily to remove the strike as an option.

Class, Gender, and Residential Service Organizations

Class

Although the majority of RSO employees, including management, are trade union members, bureaucratic inequalities due to hierarchy and the importation of people at the upper levels from higher social class backgrounds recreate, at a microlevel, class relations of the wider society. Most RSO directors have at least some qualifications—such as social work or nursing—whereas few lower-level workers do. It is doubtful that those who select RSO managers (e.g. county social service administrators and voluntary organization advisory committees) intentionally select directors because of their higher class standing. Efforts to secure the 'more qualified' candidate, however, often lead to this result (Offe 1976). Trade union organization among workers therefore represents one effort to counteract the authority and deference associated with class inequalities which are imported into and recreated in the RSO.

RSO residents also are primarily from low income backgrounds and are generally of Caucasian descent. The well-to-do 'take care of their own', either maintaining them in the home with servants or other support services (or, if residential care is necessary, placing them in private facilities to which social researchers typically lack access) and many ethnic groups care for their 'dependent needy' by incorporating them into the extended network of family relations (cf. Osmond and Martin 1983). RSO residents tend, therefore, to be similar in ethnicity and class to the workers who 'take care of' them. This generalization applies more to old peoples' homes and probation hostels than to children's homes. This may reflect the higher value placed by society and by personal social service workers on children and working with children (Adam 1979a, 1979b, 1979c; Davis 1981) than the elderly or 'criminals'. Due to the higher status of working with children, workers from higher class backgrounds can be recruited to perform this work. In addition, children's home staff receive somewhat higher pay than workers in other contexts.

Gender

An understanding of the role of unions in RSOs requires recognition that their work force is predominantly female (Davies 1979; Martin 1980). Female workers in children's homes are mostly young, single women who view their jobs as interim employment while those in old peoples' homes are primarily wives and mothers supplementing family income. Low wages, a lack of internal advancement opportunities, the unskilled nature of their work, and their youth or the double burden of family and job responsibilities make them vulnerable to budget cutbacks and threats of redundancies and diminish their commitment to job, work organization, and trade union. The historical failure of unions to benefit women materially in gaining access to favoured job sectors or positions of authority is well documented (Marglin 1976; Bibb and Form 1977). The

relatively low level of RSO worker militancy (compared to workers in production organizations or other service sectors such as the post office and transportation) may reflect not only effects of the 'ideology of service' but cultural, labour market, and other structural conditions which segregate women workers into less advantaged market sectors and low-skill, low paying jobs, and predispose them (and others in similar conditions) against both collective organization and industrial action (Brown 1976; Martin 1980; Martin et al. 1982).

Discussion

As noted by Lipsky (1980), the ability of the personal social service manager to supervise workers' activities is limited—primarily by the nature of the raw material itself. Residents, the 'objects' of work in RSOs, are proactive, unpredictable human beings, at times demanding and disruptive, at others showing dislike for some staff and preference for others. Additionally, residents sometimes steal from each other, have fist fights, and plead for the workers' attention. Such events make the 'routinization' of work extremely problematic. Considerable staff effort is required simply to 'render order' from the not infrequent disorder which characterizes an organization serving as sole residence for sizeable numbers of unrelated people who often have little to do and nowhere else to go.

Due, in part, to the pervasive 'service ideology' which claims that residents' 'needs' take precedence over workers' material interests, certain aspects of resident 'treatment' are nonnegotiable. Few staff would say that old people should be treated rudely or ignored or that 'bad' kids should be whacked or abandoned. On a concrete, experiential level, however, resident treatment is variable. Staff may in fact ignore, shout at, or curse at residents. They may pit one child against another or a child against a staff member. Some residents are favoured over others and some are treated with a surliness and roughness which might be perceived by outsiders as bordering on abuse. Both workers and management use various aspects of the 'ideology of service' to control residents and their behaviours (see Martin 1981). Workers adjure residents to do certain things and desist from others by 'service ideology' appeals such as 'It's for your own good', 'This is what you need', or 'I'm trying to help you'. Management similarly use this ideology to control workers ('You must do this for the residents' sake') as well as residents. This point highlights the qualitative distinction between work with nonhuman (vs. human) raw materials where appeals for conformity or rule-compliance are unlikely to be couched in terms of the *intrinsic enhancement of the object of work itself*. Even where product managers implore workers to improve product quality, the request is ultimately for reasons extrinsic to the product per se—e.g. increased profits, greater pride in one's work, better reputation, greater benefits—rather than the intrinsic interest of the product qua product (e.g. in RSOs, to make residents happy, self-reliant, etc.).

A predominant theme in the literature on 'progressive' residential services (Davis 1981; Wolins and Wozner 1982) is that the facility is the residents' *home*. If eating, sleeping, and residing in a building make it home, so it is. For the staff, however, there is little question of the RSOs' status. They are workplaces, analogous to factories for production workers, where staff go, for part of a day, to exchange labour for financial compensation. The existence and growth of trade unions in the social services underscores recognition by workers that, despite ideological claims that RSOs are *homes* and their work, a *service*, RSOs are work organizations and their work is paid labour. The workers' interests, furthermore, are not necessarily those of their employers (or the state) or, for that matter, the residents for whom they are 'responsible'.

It is into this complex, unpredictable, and changeable arena that trade unions insert themselves in negotiating the division of labour and job responsibilities of RSO staff. Most unions, at least in Europe, negotiate the nature of work and degree of workers' control over work (Schmidman 1979). Management often resist such efforts by reference to 'technological imperatives' claimed necessary to increase productivity, efficiency, or quality (Clegg and Dunkerley 1980). Similar discussions in the personal social services are complicated by the moral/ethical aspects of 'processing' the raw material (Levy 1982). In one sense, labour-management negotiations over the nature of work in RSOs are negotiations over the *nature and rights of the residents themselves*. The presumed 'dependency' of residents on functions performed by staff and the fundamental indeterminacy of exactly what should be done for residents renders all such discussions exceedingly complex. Philosophical conceptions of what the residents 'need' are not only culturally relative but basically normative and ideological rather than 'factual' (cf. Morris 1976; Davis 1981; Wolins and Wozner 1982). Unions which bargain for staff to have overnight responsibilities or provide expanded 'services' for residents may unwittingly foster client dependency rather than self-responsibility and well-being (Martin and Segal 1977). In light of the expanding welfare state and personal social services, issues such as these deserve greater attention in the organizational and industrial relations literature.

Notes

1. Paper read in the session on 'Power Conflicts and Decision-Making in Organizations', Research Committee 17 (on Organizations), International Sociological Association; Tenth World Congress of Society, Mexico City, Mexico, August 15-22, 1982.
2. Gratitude is expressed to Barry A. Turner for editorial and substantive comments on an earlier draft of this paper.

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